

MAMATA SAYS ROYAL HONORIFICS ARE OUT OF PLACE IN A DEMOCRACY, BUT AMRITA ROY (ABOVE), SAYS SHE HAS ALWAYS BEEN FONDLY CALLED 'RANI MA'

say a Rajasthan or Madhya Pradesh. An oft-quoted example is Uday Chand Mahtab, former maharaja of Burdwan, who tried to extend his lease on power via democracy as a Congress candidate in Bengal's first assembly polls in 1952. He was defeated by Binoy Krishna Chaudhury of the CPI by a margin of 1,962 votes. He had recently lost his estate after the Zamindari Abolition and Land Reforms Act (1951), and the mandate handed to him by those whom he once ruled didn't go down well with him. Mahtab left Burdwan in 1953, never to return. Though, in an epilogue, his wife Radharani Mahtab defeated Chaudhury in 1962.

Sarbajit Jash, who teaches history at the University of Burdwan, references that episode to add a technical point: "To refer to Amrita Roy as a queen is technically incorrect. Unlike Radharani—who had been a queen until her estate was abolished—Roy has never been one." But Roy tells INDIA TODAY that she has always been referred to as 'Rani ma' informally. "It is an affectionate way of referring to me and has no feudal connotation," she says.

Her evident disconnect from politics is an issue, though. On March 30, Arjun Biswas, who heads the BJP's Nadia North unit, admitted to a group of saffron workers that he had never seen Roy until her nomination. With Roy herself sitting by his side, Biswas tried his best to talk up "the queen", but unwittingly ended up voicing the concerns harboured by many BJP workers.

Much of Roy's putative mass appeal is expected to come from Raja Krishnachandra Roy—the 18th century king of Nadia and the most illustrious figure of the clan. An efficient administrator and promoter of arts, culture and the Bengali language, his is a revered name in Bengal. However, it is also a delicate matter of fact that he sided with the East India Company and Mir Jafar against the last potentate of Bengal, Siraj-ud-Daulah. The TMC has gleefully pounced on that, linking Roy to her husband's 39th forebear, and highlighting Krishnachandra's links to the 'traitor' Mir Jafar. As a riposte, Roy says Krishnachandra fought "the tyranny of Siraj" and "defended sanatana dharma and the Bengali language" that were, according to her, under threat from Bengal's last nawab.

Not everyone is impressed with this saffron attempt at a 'connect' with Bengal. Says analyst Subhasish Maitra, "Fielding Roy, invoking Krishnachandra and referring to her as the queen reflects BJP's dearth of local icons and disconnect with the ethos of Bengal." However, the BJP hopes it can pull off a repeat of 1999, when it had won Krishnanagar. Mahua had debuted in the Lok Sabha in 2019 by defeating the BJP's Kalyan Choubey by a margin of 63,218 votes here. With its 33 per cent Muslim vote, a touch of polarisation around 'Hindu royalty' is what the BJP feels may help. ■



RAJU SANADI

Western Maharashtra's Sangli, commonly referred to as 'Natya Pandhari' or the Mecca of the Marathi theatre industry, has been witnessing a different kind of drama of late. It was in this erstwhile princely state that Vishnudas Bhave had staged the first modern Marathi play—the *sangeet natak* (musical drama) *Sita Swayamwar*—back in 1843. But today the Lok Sabha constituency, sprawled along the first southward arc of the Krishna river, is a proscenium for chancy events, hosting scenes and acts that may bend the Opposition's rainbow coalition towards a messy denouement.

The roots of the row lie in allies Congress and the Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray) both staking claim to the constituency, foreclosing a smooth passage for the Maharashtra Vikas Aghadi's (MVA) seat-sharing talks here. It was perhaps fated to be a fraught exercise all over Maharashtra, with both the Uddhav Sena and the third big MVA constituent, Sharad Pawar's Nationalist Congress Party (NCP), looking for popular justice after being reduced to rump outfits by the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP).

But Sangli, a traditional Con-